

froggy

July 4 (c)—© typeface by Chris Lozos

Inspired by a Typophile Battle Week involving ligature madness with Cooper Black. Froggy was my double “g” ligature carried on to something else, a semi-serif.

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Quietly Quietly yikes!

Plunk your magic twanger, Froggy!

Hiya, kids, Hiya, hiya!

The Buster Brown TV Show with Smilin' Ed McConnell and his Buster Brown Gang (later the title was mercifully shortened to 'Smilin' Ed's Gang').

11 point:

This NBC Saturday evening children's series was sponsored by Buster Brown shoes starting in 1950, and was basically a TV version of McConnell's popular and long-running radio program (1944-1952).

The backdrop was a clubhouse, with kids in the studio audience. Produced on a very small budget, the show was a success—bringing the Buster Brown advertising characters to life and helping to sell millions of shoes based on icons that had existed for decades. It was also one of the first kid shows filmed in Hollywood.

The folksy broadcast was hosted by old-timer Smilin' Ed McConnell; music and stories from Smilin' Ed's Storybook were regular features. The show also featured "Gunga, the East India Boy," a serial set in India. Led by The Maharajah, Gunga Ram and his pal Rama set out on great adventures around the village of Bakore in filmed segments.

The most popular segment was the visit from Froggy the Gremlin who would appear when Smilin' Ed yelled his famous catch-phrase, "Plunk your Magic Twanger, Froggy!" Don't ask me what a 'Magic Twanger' was!

The Smilin' Ed Show was moved to Saturday mornings in 1951, where it ran on CBS and ABC (as 'Smilin' Ed's Gang') until 1954 when the Ed McConnell died suddenly of a heart attack.

And alot of that money was due to the "Buster Brown Show" and Froggy the Gremlin. For this show, Ed had the right sponsor, and great support from producer Frank Ferrin, writer Hobart Donavan (who also wrote the Buster Brown comic book giveaways) and director Arthur Jacobson.

When Ed started his hit kiddie show, radio audiences knew Buster Brown faintly...from a 1929 radio series on CBS. By the time Smilin Ed' got his kiddie show, Buster Brown was no longer well remembered as a comic strip, the character was merely the trademark symbol for a shoe company.

Buster Brown and Smilin' Ed collided in 1944, with "Smilin' Ed's Buster Brown Gang" taking to the airwaves on September 2nd. The show continued on NBC radio every Saturday morning at 11:30 through April 11, 1953.

The format rarely varied. There was an adventure story to open the show, a lot of plugs for Buster Brown shoes,

and finally towards the end, Froggy the Gremlin might sing a song or annoy a guest (such as Shortfellow the Poet or Alkali Pete the Cowboy). Midnight the Cat actually spoke a few lines now and then, and Smilin' Ed was always prone to sing a novelty song (or two).

Yes, Ed would invite Froggy to come out and make make himself visible by plunking his magic twanger!

"Plunking" may have come from Ed's habit of plunking the strings on his piano to emphasize some of the action in his stories. (The piano was actually named "Grandy the Piano," as if it was alive.)

Ed was the voice of Froggy, putting on a low, gruff, Popeye-like croak.

However...whenever Ed had to sing a duet WITH Froggy, announcer Archie Presby was the voice of Froggy. And when there was a live audience, Archie would sometimes dress up in a frog costume and carry on to the delight of the screaming kids.

Presby was a staff announcer for NBC. Back in 1937 he performed his duties on a radio variety show called "Bughouse Rhythm." Variety reviewed the show and noted: "Program is nicely laid out, in that quaint croaking narrator, G. Archibald Presby, treats each (jazz) player with dignity...all are introduced and referred to as 'Mr.'"

The full cast of the radio show included June Foray, Wendall Noble, Conrad Binyon, John Dehner and Jimmy Ogg. They took part in the adventure stories. June was called upon to voice Midnight and Bud Tollefson, the sound effects engineer, growled the voice of Tige the Dog.

Smilin' Ed used the show to promote not only the Buster Brown shoes, but the comic books, which featured Ed and usually a little story involving the "Buster Brown Gang" of Midnight, Squeaky and Froggy. To his credit, Ed would tell the kiddies that

they could go to their local store and get a comic book WITHOUT having to make a purchase!

FROGGY THE GREMLIN

He made people look stupid.

He laughed at "squares."

He perfected "mind control" and "subliminal suggestion" before the Cold War era began.

He jeered authority and cheered humorous disobedience. He only had kind words for his cult followers:

"Hiya kids, hiya hiya."

While Moe had Larry & Curly, and Spike Jones had his City Slickers, Froggy the Gremlin worked alone. That's part of why he has such a unique one-to-one appeal in our memory. He was the lone class clown, the one "bad apple" in the barrel, the one wart on the helping hand.

Remember when you were a kid, and adults kept giving you another chance to be good and behave? On "Andy's Gang," Andy Devine, that big symbol of authority, invited the Gremlin to come out and behave himself... "Plunk Your Magic Twanger, Froggy!"

In a puff of smoke, Froggy appeared, laughing, hopping from side to side, that fixed and evil grin on his face.

Andy thought THIS TIME, Froggy might behave like a responsible adult. But the kids in the audience knew

better! Froggy relished practical jokes, dirty tricks, and interrupting any “guest” who was giving a lecture that involved learning something! In the audience, kids screamed with delight, half of them howling and trying to get out of their seats.

The history of Froggy the Gremlin is a swamp of mystery. Nobody paid much attention to kiddie shows, so there aren’t any newspaper clippings about Froggy. By the time people realized how warped Froggy was, the program was over, the damage was done and the perpetrators long dead.

The legend began on radio.

Froggy made his debut in a kiddie show hosted by Smilin’ Ed McConnell. He was the Father of Froggy, pleasant, jolly and full of fun and fantasies.

When Smilin’ Ed unveiled his “Buster Brown Gang” show in 1944, audiences didn’t know what to expect. Buster Brown had been the subject of a brief 1929 radio series on CBS, and that was now a dim memory. And so was R. F. Outcault, who had died in 1928.

R.F. Outcault (1863-1928) was the cartoonist who created the Buster Brown strip in 1902. It debuted in the New York Herald.

You want me to get back to the story of Froggy. OK. Smilin’ Ed’s show was a hit. He’d be sure to open every episode with a subliminal shoe reference (“Come running”) and pepper the show with references to his one and only sponsor.

Frank Ferren was the producer and Hobart Donovan was the officially credited writer. He definitely wrote the long “adventure” scripts that took up most of the show’s half hour. But it seems that the novelty songs were written by Smilin’ Ed, and the comical segments with Froggy the Gremlin were done by Harry Stewart, a struggling cornball comedian who was

slowly beginning a career as a novelty singer and character comic under the name Yogi Yorgesson.

The characters of Froggy the Gremlin, Midnight the Cat and Squeaky the Mouse were not in the Buster Brown strip; they were all invented for the radio show.

“Smilin’ Ed’s Buster Brown Gang” took to the airwaves on September 2nd. His long run on NBC radio would continue every Saturday morning at 11:30 through April 11, 1953.

The Buster Brown comic books, given out free, eventually began to feature not only adventure stories, but funny adventures involving Smilin’ Ed and his Gang.

As with the latter TV show adventures (featuring Gunga Ram) the radio and comic book adventures involving kid heroes, genies and pirates were not exactly riveting. Today it’s Froggy the Gremlin that accounts for most of the interest in the radio show, comic books and TV series.

For many kids, a sign of puberty was getting sick of that Buster Brown label inside your shoe and wanting to wear a normal brand of footwear.

Into the harmless world of radio adventure stories and Buster Brown comic books came a certain amphibian-poltergeist. He was dressed, mockingly, in a red jacket, white shirt and black tie. But he had no pants on.

Was he a ghost, space creature or leprechaun? A little guy with a frog’s head?

Was he a frog that became a gremlin? A gremlin that had become a frog? Where exactly was his “twanger” and how did he “plunk” it? Nobody really knew much about the magical, mysterious.....

FROGGY THE GREMLIN.

He was the star attraction. Eventually he appeared on many Buster Brown comic book covers, and.....

By 1948 the Rempel Company began to market a Froggy the Gremlin. Yes, he was now infiltrating homes.

While the Froggy doll remains the most sought-after item for Gremlin-philes, there is a lot of other stuff out there.

If you'd like a close-up on the feet... clickity-click! And for children who want to actually BE the mischievous gremlin, a paper Froggy mask...

\$50 for the mask is not uncommon. What would a simple piece of cardboard with a "froggy flicker" image on it cost at an Internet auction?

Those who visited a Buster Brown store may have been confronted by a bizarre "in store" display. Three dimensional, motorized so that the figures actually moved, the wooden stage (five feet by three feet) must have made kids gasp and parents cringe. Let's test your reaction...

Highly prized: the box the shoes came in, because Froggy was on the box (he was, he was)...

REMEMBERING BUSTER BROWN'S ORIGIN AND COMIC BOOK FROGGY

by Ronald L. Smith

Here's more than you'll ever want to know about the origin of Buster Brown shoes and the creation of the Buster Brown comic strip....

In 1878, George Warren Brown and Alvin Bryan started the Bryan, Brown and Company manufacturing plant in St. Louis. Their big product was Brown Shoes, and in 1893 that became the company name. That's about as dull and plain as a brown shoe gets.

Meanwhile, in 1902, a fellow named Richard F. Outcault was launching a new comic strip in New York. (That's

Outcault at the top of this page). The hero would be a sort of sissified kid named Buster Brown. Why? Because the successful OLD comic strip had come under fire for being too nasty. The lead character was a kind of Bart Simpson brat known as The Yellow Kid.

As you can see, the nasty brat was enough of a legend to eventually become immortalized on a U.S. postage stamp.

But back around the turn of the century, The Yellow Kid had run afoul of bluenoses, and that was interfering with Outcault earning his green. Some wordsmiths insist that the term "yellow journalism" came from "the yellow papers," the newspapers sleazy enough to carry the appalling antics of The Yellow Kid.

The Yellow Kid, like subsequent blond brats Dennis the Menace and Bart Simpson, had become a great marketing item. Only instead of t-shirts, The Yellow Kid turned up hawking such adult products as beer and alcohol!

Outcault finally gave in and decided to create a new kid hero, an upscale boy with a milder streak of mischief. Think: The Yellow Kid is to the Three Stooges what Buster Brown is to The Cosby Show.

As you can see, Buster was quite a different fellow from the notorious Yellow Kid. Outcault had success with this new character and in 1904 went out to St. Louis for the World's Fair, intent on marketing the new character for ads, posters, and any other product he could find.

The fair, which had its own theme song in "Meet Me in St. Louis" was a rousing success and amid the greed and merriment Richard Outcault, Buster Brown hawker, met up with George Warren Brown, Brown Shoe maker. It was a perfect fit.

Of all the licenses Outcault sold, the one to the Brown Shoe company proved the most lucrative. The Brown

Shoe Company took an aggressive marketing approach for their new Buster Brown line. They hired short people (at the time, the term was “midgets”) to impersonate Buster Brown at stores and theaters. Sometimes Buster Brown brought along his dog Tige and an entire cast for shows. That type of thing definitely brought the rubes ‘a running. The idea was so successful that the idea of a grown-up Buster was continued throughout the run of Smilin’ Ed and Andy’s Gang on TV, Buster Brown was played not by a child, but by an adult, Jerry Narron.

For many, Jerry’s squealing commercial that begins “I’m Buster Brown, I live in a shoe...” still resonates....

Sing the Buster Brown shoe song

Does your shoe have a dog inside?
What a funny place for a dog to hide
Does your shoe have a boy there too
A boy and a dog and a foot in a shoe
well the boy is buster brown
And the dog is Tige his friend.
And its really just a picture
But its fun to play pretend!
So look, look, look
In your telephone book
For the store that sells the shoe, with the picture
boy and the dog inside too!

10 point

That you can put your foot into The “Buster Brown” shoe line still exists, but the Brown Shoe Company rakes in \$1.6 billion in sales with the help of other brands such as Naturalizer, LifeStride and Connie shoes for women.

In 2002 NPR radio’s Morning Edition celebrated the 100 year anniversary of the Outcault strip. Reporter Elizabeth Blair described the series this way: “In almost every strip, Buster Brown wore short pants, a little jacket, and dainty Victorian shoes and sometimes a wide, saucer-rimmed hat. His family was rich, which appealed to upper class New Yorkers.”

At the end of his adventures, Buster Brown would often insist: ‘I’m sorry I was bad, I promise never to do that again, I’ll be a good boy from now on.’

Yes, Froggy the Gremlin’s “I’ll be good, I will, I will,” came directly from Buster Brown.

yy

Die Werbung zur großen
Weimarer Bauhaus
Baño Quality Care
when will trees grow?
when will trees grow?
this though fits
discretionary ligs off

Q

9 point

Cyrus Highsmith on boss David Berlow

Published on July 28, 2004.

Filed in Design heroes and Typography.

I started working at Font Bureau in 1997. One morning, not long after I started, I went up to my boss David Berlow's office to show him a typeface I had been working on. It was an early version of Dispatch, one of my first serious projects. I climbed the stairs slowly, calling hello loudly to let David know I was coming. He was at his desk, silhouetted in front of his large windows. "Come on in" he said, without looking up from drawing. I stumbled over to his desk, handed him my proofs, and sat down on the steps behind him. David looked at them for a while and started commenting on the spacing, and how the serifs related to each other. At the time, I was the most junior designer, and I listened hard, handing him a pen so he could make notes and draw what he meant. When we were finished discussing the proofs, I found that I still had plenty to work on, but I felt encouraged. I asked, "Do you like it?"

He responded with the crooked smile that he saves for explaining something he has thought about often. "If you ask a shepherd if he likes his sheep and he answers, 'I like that one for its wool, that one for its meat, and that one for making new sheep' - you know he is a good shepherd. If he answers, 'I like that cute one over there' - you know he has other things on his mind," David said, smiling even more.

I understood what he meant. David was not concerned if he liked a typeface or not. He was concerned with whether it could be used for something, which is a smart way to build a good library of fonts. But later, after David's statement had really sunk in, it also began to affect that way I work and think. It does not mean every typeface has to be plain and utilitarian. It means thinking deeply about the designers who will use your typeface to design pages and the readers who will read them.

There are forces at work in the design of typefaces that need to be balanced. There is the balance between experimentation, pushing the limits of typography, and serving your reader, giving them something comfortable that doesn't get in the way. There is a balance between personal taste or style, and just plain vanity. I have to figure out how to balance these variables with each project. That means trying things, going too far and upsetting their balance until it seems right.

I repeat David's advice to my students at Rhode Island School of Design (RISD) when we discuss their typefaces. They think I am nuts

at first. Students like to please their teachers -- they want to know how to draw something that I will like. But usually they get it after a while and at the end of the semester, we have a diverse bunch of typefaces for all different uses, and the students are impressed by what the class has accomplished. David's story is just a story about sheep, but the attitude that I learned from him as a junior designer continues to influence my drawing, my teaching, and my relationship to livestock of all kinds.

Werkstatt Typographie und Reklame

In den ersten Jahren des Weimarer Bauhauses spielte die Typographie noch nicht die zentrale Rolle, die ihr später zukam. Schrift war für Bauhausmeister wie Johannes Itten oder Lothar Schreyer in erster Linie ein künstlerisches Ausdrucksmittel. Praktische Anwendungen waren anfangs selten und blieben auf kleinere Drucksachen beschränkt.

Die Situation änderte sich 1923 grundlegend mit der Berufung Moholy-Nagys, der die Ideen der Neuen Typographie am Bauhaus einführte. Schrift galt ihm vor allem als Medium der Kommunikation; es ging ihm um "klare Mitteilung in ihrer eindringlichsten Form". Die Werbung zur großen Weimarer Bauhaus-Ausstellung im Sommer 1923 zeigt bereits deutlich seinen Einfluß. Moholy-Nagy entwarf das Layout für die Begleitpublikation zur Ausstellung und übernahm dann auch die typographische Gestaltung für die 1925 eröffnete Reihe der "Bauhausbücher".

Von nun an war die Typographie am Bauhaus ganz wesentlich mit der Eigenwerbung, mit der Entwicklung eines unverwechselbaren Erscheinungsbildes für die Schule verbunden. Gestaltungsmittel waren klare, schmucklose Druckschriften, die Gliederung und Akzentuierung der Seiten durch einprägsame Zeichen oder farbige typographische Elemente, schließlich eine direkte Information durch die Verbindung von Schrift und Fotografie, für die der Begriff "Typofoto" geprägt wurde.

Hinzu kam der Aspekt der Ökonomie im Gebrauch genormter Formate und zeitweise auch einer vereinfachten Orthographie, insbesondere der Kleinschreibung.

Neben Moholy-Nagy traten schon in Weimar auch Joost Schmidt und Herbert Bayer hervor. Bayer übernahm am Bauhaus Dessau die Leitung der neu eingerichteten Druck- und Reklamewerkstatt und konnte sie innerhalb kurzer Zeit zu einem professionell arbeitenden Atelier für Graphik-Design ausbauen. Er arbei-

tete intensiv an der Entwicklung avantgardistischer Druckschriften, und in seinen Plakaten und Drucksachen zeigt sich die Auseinandersetzung mit den aktuellen Erkenntnissen der Werbepsychologie.

18 point:

Bayer hat nach dem Ausscheiden aus dem Bauhaus im Jahre 1928 seine Arbeit zunächst in Deutschland, später in den USA fortgeführt und wurde zu einem der einflußreichsten Graphik-Designer des zwanzigsten Jahrhunderts.

Seine Nachfolge am Bauhaus übernahm Joost Schmidt. Er führte einen systematischen Unterricht für Schriftentwurf und Werbegraphik ein, den er nun auch auf die Praxis des Ausstellungsdesigns ausdehnte. Anwendungsmöglichkeiten für experimentelle Präsentationsformen aus Architektur, Plastik, Fotografie und Typographie boten sich in Wanderausstellungen des Bauhauses ebenso wie auf Messen im In- und Ausland, die von der Werbewerkstatt gestaltet wurden.

dezcom

27 June, 2006 - 8:00pm

Froggy—Inspired by a Typophile Battle Week involving ligature madness with Cooper Black. Froggy was my double “g” ligature carried on to something else, a semi-serif. It is pretty early in the development but I am trying to get it ready for the Type Battle display at TypeCon by July 5th or Tiffany will see to it that I get worts :-)

William Berkson

27 June, 2006 - 9:30pm

Hi Chris. I like the feeling of this generally as a friendly, readable display face. I can see it being used in ads a lot.

Something is a bit off about the top of the e; I’m not sure what. But the main problem are the diagonal characters—here vwyz. To me they really stick out like sore thumbs—they don’t seem like part of the same face. If you can find a more harmonious solution for these, I think this can be a winner.

BlueJ

27 June, 2006 - 11:12pm

I’m way far from being qualified to do any critic, but I’d like to share some of my thoughts in the hope of being of some use.

I agree with William about the general feeling and I think that there’s something strange in the lowercase e’s counter (it feels strange to have the upper right as an almost straight corner).

I love ligatures and the ones you’ve designed so far are definitely interesting (I really love the “gh”), but the “is” and “ts” ones seem to slightly slip forward, especially when they’re inside a word.

Are you planning also to add lining figures?
andi emery

28 June, 2006 - 7:12am

I have to tell you, Chris, the “f” and “r” characters are just so beautiful - they really sing. There is something about the shapes of the counters that make the counterspace just as interesting as the actual glyphs.

Although I love the slant of the “y”, it doesn’t seem to be playing nicely with the other letters. As William mentioned, it sticks out far too much. The “f” seems to have a bit of a funny slant to it as well - ever so slight, but noticeable in the smaller size.

This is a font on my “Must Have” list, Chris - elegant and different - inspirational!

Miss Tiffany

28 June, 2006 - 3:59pm

Chris this really is interesting and you shouldn’t avoid this one. I can see it going much heavier as well as much lighter into almost a typewriter-like weight.

I agree that the _y_ seems a little too stiff. I like the _v_ and _w_ though.

dezcom

28 June, 2006 - 6:08pm

THANK YOU ALL!!!

Above is PDF #2 with new v,w,y and some kerns.

I am planning a range of weights Tiff and lining figures jacopo. What is meant by “slip forward”?

ChrisL

dezcom

28 June, 2006 - 6:35pm

Good catch Andi,

“The “f” seems to have a bit of a funny slant to it as well ”

Is this only with certain glyphs or all? It may be the typical illusion you get with italic f where it seems to fall forward more than the others. I will try back-slanting it a tad but, as you noticed, it is less visible when larger and I need to find the balance point.

ChrisL

dezcom

28 June, 2006 - 6:47pm

For those of you youngin’s who never saw early 1950s kids TV, here is what the TV character “Froggy” looked like:

ChrisL

William Berkson

28 June, 2006 - 7:19pm

Hi Chris. I like the new ‘y’ better. But the ‘v’ and ‘w’ are still problems. To me because of the bent right diagonals they look like italic characters mistakenly dropped into a roman font. If you compare Souvenir, where he has bent diagonals, he bends both sides in the roman and carries it throughout the face, caps and lc alike, except for the z.

Here I think the v and w might work with just

straight right sides like the y, or with your rounded corner serifs, this time turned outward to the right. Even with this the face will have lots of soft features, and will keep its overall look I think.

On the caps, my feeling is that there are too many serifs. The most successful semi-serif caps I think are Rotis Semi-Serif's and he just put one top left serif on everything. Somehow it works in combination with other caps or lc. It seems to be quite widely used. The only problem is the M. To me the top right vertex looks painfully chopped off in Rotis semi-serif, and even more so here. So I would try adding a serif there—against what I am saying otherwise. Or if you don't, in any case the right stem of the M can be lightened with benefit I suspect.

The unique look of this face is that it manages to be soft but clean looking. Cooper Black is soft but not as clean. Sauna has something of it, but is more soft, with a lot of italic details. Here you have more sharpness.

Anyway, this I think is a unique look that still can be very usable—something not easy to achieve, but you're almost there, I think. Very impressive!

But I think it needs more consistency and a little more restraint to really become itself. Dr. Berkson's prescription: take two MFB (Morris Fuller Benton) pills and they will do wonders for you :)

dezcom

28 June, 2006 - 7:23pm

" take two MFB (Morris Fuller Benton) pills and call me in the morning."

LOL!!!

Thanks William, I'll take another look at the caps.

ChrisL

William Berkson

28 June, 2006 - 7:25pm

Oh, you quoted me before I revised for (appropriate) humility :)

Bluej

29 June, 2006 - 5:09am

Hey! Froggy really looks like your gg ligature!

I guess "slip forward" is not exactly a technical expression... What I meant is that looking at those two ligatures I have the feeling that they're about to (I'm sorry but I really lack the appropriate word) fall on their back, by back

meaning the left side of the glyph.

Now of course the more I look at them and the more my eyes get used so that feeling might just be something to do not take in consideration.

I'm quite curious about how a lighter cut will look because I believe it will be really interesting as a text face.

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 5:09am

William,

Your edit kills the joke though!

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 7:45am

jacopo,

"Now of course the more I look at them and the more my eyes get used so that feeling might just be something to do not take in consideration."

All of these things we see in type are "illusions" but that is the visual world we live in as designers. Some illusions are transient or are only affected in some rare glyph combinations and perhaps are not an issue. Others may come into play often and need a correction—sometimes this is just a kern and sometimes a redraw is required. The difficulty with a new typeface is that it has not settled yet in the viewers eyes and subsequent viewings may erase the problematic vision. I don't know if this is the case so we will let it percolate a bit longer :-)

This may well turn out to be a viable text face at the lighter weights. First I have to battle this weight through and hope you will help with comments on progress of all coming weights.

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 7:49am

William,

The cap "I" can be confused with the lwercas "l" (elle) if I take out the serifs top right and bottom left. This opens the dilemma with the "j" and "h" so I am still fighting with it.

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 7:51am

William,

I also see a semi-serif as an iatly asymmetrical face so the v and w seem open to more asymmetrical treatment to me.

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 7:55am

Rotis is a sem-sans and more geometric in nature. It has more the feel of a slab serif than Froggy.

ChrisL

William Berkson

29 June, 2006 - 8:49am

>>asymmetrical treatment

I think you can do asymmetrical, like the y you did. My problem is not so much with asymmetrical as with consistency. You don't have the bent right diagonal in the kxyz, nor any of the caps (though you can follow somewhat different rules there). That's why it sticks out to my eyes. (by the way, I think the x with the two squiggles is too fussy and needs to be simplified.)

I pointed to MF Benton, because he took totally different styles like Broadway and Franklin Gothic and identified and carried through their logic with beautiful consistency and even color.

On the caps, like everything else, you can of course do anything you can pull off. Rotis semi-serif (not the semi-sans) is not geometric though not as modulated as much as Froggy. I was just pointing to it as one of the few successful semi-serifs to ponder.

Thinking about it further, I think the problem for my eyes with a lot of semi-serifs is that going half way, like on the current Froggy H, makes characters look mutilated to me.

I think you could also go the other way on the caps: eg put small serifs on everything in the Caps except the thin strokes—you are almost there in your current version anyway. Or some variation, but with just leaving a few serifs discretely off, so the absence of them does not shout at you.

Overall, I think there is a danger in trying to do too many things in one typeface. You have achieved a really nice distinctive look with your lower case, and I think the 'Benton pills' would make you just create good caps that work with it, and not try to be too innovative on the caps. After all, Benton was going to do over 100 faces—and you are so full of interesting ideas, you just might as well!

Nick Job

29 June, 2006 - 9:30am

Very good, as usual.

Comma (and tilde) worries me a bit - too thin/light maybe?

I can see why you've done the e like that (like the c and the f to a certain extent). But why isn't the r like it? I would prefer c, e and f to match the smooth and curvy r and not have the angle which is distracting.

If your H is going to have outer serifs, then shouldn't it have smooth curves on inside rather than corners. Like William B says, looks like some sort of chopping has occurred.

On the gh ligature I would make the g dominate and lose the pointy curve in favour of a gentler one inside.

j would benefit from more closely resembling the cap J which has a prettier hook.

I think William B is right, this would benefit massively from an audit and then a rigorous drive for consistency between characters. Hope that won't make it lose its character.

It's a robust concept though and I think I have sounded far too negative.

Keep going.

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 10:55am

Thanks Nick,

I know it needs much work and was just trying to force it along to make the July 5th deadline. As usual, haste makes waste.

ChrisL

BruceS63

29 June, 2006 - 12:02pm

Do you think it'll sell in France?

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 12:04pm

"Do you think it'll sell in France?"

Perhaps only the decenders since frogs legs are a delicacy there:-)

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 12:10pm

Or maybe I should post an ad for it here?

<http://www.frogg.splinder.com/?from=20>

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 12:18pm

Or perhaps here:

<http://www.froggydelight.com/>

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 2:28pm

“On the gh ligature I would make the g dominate and lose the pointy curve in favour of a gentler one inside”

That is the way I had it originally and it looked too much like a g waering a hat because of the large countewrspace.

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 5:35pm

“by the way, I think the x with the two squiggles is too fussy and needs to be simplified.”

I am surprised no one has mentioned this before. This is the glyph I am the least happy with. I shold have fixed it a week ago.

ChrisL

dezcom

29 June, 2006 - 7:27pm

Here is version 3 pdf with the caps revisited and the x fixed; the punctuation made bolder and a few other things I want to see if you can notice.

ChrisL

Nick Job

30 June, 2006 - 1:50am

I'd make the y like the v (ie with a point bottom left). People will get used to it!

B counters: I would make the other inner corner rounded (not the top one) which will echo the penstroke. Ditto D which should have one point and only one round which will help distinguish further from the O.

Prefer the H with less serifs but would try curving the arms (on the arms with serifs).

I think the foot of the a should echo foot of u.

Lower comma slightly.

Tail of C shouldn't come round to horizontal. Take the cue from c and e.

Middle leg of m I would square off. You should

only go round the corner if there is an associated serif.

s looks very wide compare to surrounding characters.

Left arm of w should be more sloped to look a little more like v. It looks too vertical (even italic!) and is conspicuous in text. (3rd stroke also too vertical).

Keep going - it's got a great feel in text - I find it really easy to read.

dezcom

30 June, 2006 - 6:01am

I am still pluggin' away at it Nick and will try some of your suggestions. My () need some work too I see.

ChrisL

William Berkson

30 June, 2006 - 6:19am

I like your changes on the caps, I think it works better now. On the L, would it be more consistent visually to chop the bottom left serif, and put it up on the right, like the I?

On the lc x, did you try using the shape of the left diagonal of the y as the left diagonal of the x? That would seem more logical, though I don't know if it gives problems.

This reads fine on screen, but at smaller sizes on the PDF it is hard for me to read. It might benefit from being tracked wider at small sizes. You might think about what sizes you anticipate it being used at, and adjust the space according.

If you don't want to have a straight diagonal on the right of the vw for the default of the face, you might consider doing one as an alternative.

dezcom

30 June, 2006 - 6:42am

William,

I am still debating with myself about the y and w problem. I know what I have is wrong but I don't want it to be just the typical treatment so I need to fight with it some more. My guess is that I will just have to throw what I have by tomorrow at the July 5th deadline and continue working for a while before I am satisfied with it.

I'll try your y to x idea as well.

ChrisL

William Berkson

30 June, 2006 - 7:22am

>I don't want it to be just the typical treatment

Christian Schwartz said something very thought provoking to me at Typecon last year: "You have to resist the temptation to put too much of yourself into a typeface." By that I think he meant that the face has to become itself, with its own nature. Like a child, it needs to be respected as having its own character, and the designer needs to work to realize that nature to the maximum. Once you have some basic ideas, it starts to have its own rules and nature, and resists you doing what *you* want.

So I am not against wanting to make any particular bit innovative. But I think that past a certain point making innovation a top priority can get in the way. Here you already have a concept that is really strong, which is an achievement. From my point of view, your challenge now is just to realize the concept most fully and effectively. I think if you *at this point* forget about being innovative and just be a servant of the typeface, it will end up with a very distinctive look anyway, and may be more effectively realized.

Interestingly, a typeface becomes *you* even when you consciously avoid it. Goudy argued against being personal in type, and thought we was not being personal. But of course almost everything of his came out shouting 'Goudy'.

dezcom

30 June, 2006 - 7:50am

"I think if you *at this point* forget about being innovative and just be a servant of the typeface,"

That is what I am trying to do. I want it to be a servant of this typeface, not just a duplication of type solutions done with other typefaces. I guess what I am saying is that the best path is neither the conscious attempt at innovation nor the conscious attempt at avoiding innovation by just adopting often-used solutions lock-step. Sometimes just trying solutions in a naive way "allows" the typeface to bring its own force to bear. As you said, "Like a child, it needs to be respected as having its own character."

ChrisL

William Berkson

30 June, 2006 - 8:09am

>Sometimes just trying solutions in a naive way "allows" the typeface to bring its own force to bear.

Good point!

dezcom

30 June, 2006 - 8:54pm

I don't know why my previous post didn't take but I just posted round 4 pdf above with many of the suggested changes as well as adding a few diacritics and some German text.

ChrisL

new

William Berkson

1 July, 2006 - 7:19am

Interesting. Nick Job was right the problem was not the v (version 3) but the w. You were right to stick with your guns on the v!

Your new w fits well with the face and has its playful quality. But it is still a little awkward. Perhaps thinning the far right diagonal will be enough to balance it. And perhaps changing its angle a bit. Another thing would be to go a different way and do two of your left squiggles like on the v and y, with thinner straight right diagonals. Perhaps you've tried and rejected that already.

I was just concentrating on structural stuff, but I agree with Nick Job that the s is too wide. Perhaps for that reason I find the ligatures with the s distracting. I hope that users will also have the option of a regular gg and gh, if for some reason they don't want to go with your playful ones.

Exciting to see you develop this, Chris!

new

paul d hunt

1 July, 2006 - 8:09am

I know it needs much work and was just trying to force it along to make the July 5th deadline.

What is this deadline???

new

paul d hunt

1 July, 2006 - 8:35am

Chris, sorry i haven't been able to get to this sooner, but you've come a long way!!! I looked at an earlier PDF, but i didn't have time to give it full attention till now. I like the new caps, the lower serif on the L bothers me most – it feels like a mistake to me. The tail of the Q feels like it was broken – like the O portion fell on it and it got squooshed. Do i see a rubby slipper on that foot sticking out from underneath? >^p i also think the top of the c and the arm on the r

should have the same treatment. i prefer the r with the smooth inner counter. smoothing out the c would also allow you to smooth out the e, which looks funny to me with that crick the way it is now. the s and e feel too wide, as does the v. i liked the old w construction better, it was just a bit wobbly before. the new w construction jumps out at me as you try to read text. is the tail on the eszett shorter than on the f? if so, why? the cedilla looks a bit alien to this face to me. your best characters imo are the g and r. the caps are very solid too. the lc just needs some quirks worked out to bring it all into harmony. keep up the good work!

Kris

This is a weird little number! It initially made me think of Heinekin, (that happy 'e'), but that passed. I am looking at pdf 8.

I think the asymmetrical serif treatment is suitable. But why is the bottom right serif on the h i l m n r slightly curved, whereas the a d q is sharp? It seems to me that a d q are prime candidates for a softer touch. The upper internal curves of B D P R are a bit funny, although I suppose they are modelled heavily from the diagonal stroke contrast of the O. The three different stroke endings on the m are interesting, the progression from square to curved serif is nice. But does it work? LC r is rotating anti-clockwise when it sits alone, and a little more in text. The text settings have a slight bottom right to top left flow, which is up to you to decide whether you like it or not!

Otherwise, I think it is a great typeface. The italics and lighter weights will be nice to see.

-K

Miss Tiffany

2 July, 2006 - 2:55pm

-W- The last stem seems angled a little to far to the right.

-X- The waist seems a hair too high.

-e- the counter seems out of place. I enjoy it, there's something nice about it, but maybe it needs to be exaggerated a little more.

-g- I think the ear needs a little more finesse or finessing. Or, maybe it is just a hair wide?

-w- there is still something off here. a little wide. maybe the curve on the last stem needs to go a little higher so the straight is not as long. that stems works in the -v- but it isn't quite working in the -w-.

Dez, you're going to have a "normal" -g- and -h- right? And allow us to have a disconnect -t- and -h-? And -i- and -s-. I find those ligatures off. Nothing personal. JFP's Costa has a ch ligature that I don't like either. There is something odd about the joining being at the bottom. (or something.)

Overall I think your numerals (figures) are a little to large. Only by a hair though.

Kris, I see the same thing as you in the lower-case -r-. I think it is a visual trick caused by the top serif facing left and the bottom curving under. But, I don't think I'd try to correct it as I don't see it when it is in formation with the other letters.

**What would a vile
dewdrop wash and
wear while stewing
over quiet Don Quixote
Don Quixote**